

WE/SYSTEMS LEARN UNCERTAINTY

1. THE LOSS OF GUARANTEES

- Why the loss of guarantees becomes one of the deepest existential shocks in history.
- How cultures invent tools — ritual, faith, chance, calculation — to negotiate the unknown.

3. WHEN ERROR BECOMES INFORMATION

- When control shifts from the artist's hand to rules, instructions, and systems. How authorship dissolves into execution, delegation, and feedback.

2. FROM ABSURDITY TO INSTRUCTION

- When randomness stops being chaos and becomes a method.
- How art begins to design conditions for emergence instead of fixed meanings.

4. DESIGNING SYSTEMS

- When form is no longer composed, but generated.
- How algorithms, emergence, and on-chain systems redefine what an artwork is..

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Uncertainty is a constant in human history, but our ways of relating to it change — from ritual and faith, to calculation, to systems and algorithms.
- Chance is not always the opposite of order. Across history, it shifts from being a creative force, to something suppressed, to something designed into systems.
- Authorship emerges together with risk. When divine and traditional guarantees collapse, the artist becomes responsible for meaning — and for being wrong.
- Modernity turns uncertainty into a calculation, pricing risk through probability, insurance, and speculation — without eliminating existential doubt.
- Scientific revolutions dismantle determinism. Quantum physics shows uncertainty as structural, not a flaw of knowledge, and makes the observer part of the system.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- After the catastrophes of the 20th century, authority loses legitimacy.
- Dada introduces chance as rupture.
- Fluxus transforms chance into a consequence of rules.
- Authorship dissolves into executable situations.
- Constraint replaces inspiration.
- The artist becomes a designer of systems. Outcomes do not pre-exist; they emerge through execution. Chance is no longer an error or accident — it is a built-in parameter of the work itself.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Mid-20th century science reframes randomness. In cybernetics and information theory, error and noise stop being failures and become sources of knowledge about how systems function.
- Systems can only regulate themselves through deviation; instability is not the opposite of order, but its condition.
- The artwork becomes the visible operation of a system, not a finished image.
- The work exists as a range of possible states. Series replace unique objects; each piece is one realization of a rule.
- The idea becomes a machine: authorship moves from execution to system design.
- LeWitt's instructions function as algorithms aimed at reproducibility; Fluxus instructions trigger events without a "correct" outcome.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Generative art is defined by a way of thinking, not by style or technology.
- Different generative systems ask different questions. Procedural systems focus on actions over time; algorithmic systems on rules and reproducibility; agent-based systems on emergence and behavior; data-driven systems on translating reality; on-chain systems on autonomy and execution.
- With computers, systems become executable. One algorithm can generate infinite variations; form becomes a trace of a procedure rather than an expressive gesture.
- Across all these systems, the artwork is not an object but a field of possible states. Meaning does not precede form — it emerges through execution.